

Week 5 — Education Pathways: Picking Your Route

Goal: Choose, with evidence, how you'd actually get the education — because “go to school for engineering” hides at least four very different routes with very different costs, timelines, and lifestyles. Read `resources/education-pathways.md` first for the map; this week you fill in the local details.

Part 1: Research

Investigate all four routes **as they actually exist where you live**:

Route 1: Community college → transfer to a 4-year engineering program

- Which community college(s) near you have an engineering or pre-engineering track?
- Do they have a **transfer agreement (articulation agreement)** with your state university's engineering school? Find the actual agreement page.
- Cost per year, class schedule options (evening? online? — matters if you're working)

Route 2: Engineering Technology degree (AS or BS in MET/EET)

- What's the difference between *engineering* and *engineering technology*? (Look up both; ask r/AskEngineers)
- Who near you offers it, what does it cost, and what jobs does it lead to?

Route 3: Apprenticeship

- For EE-leaning: IBEW electrician apprenticeships (paid from day one, “earn while you learn”). Find your local IBEW chapter and their application requirements/timeline.
- For ME-leaning: machinist/toolmaker/industrial maintenance apprenticeships — check apprenticeship.gov for registered programs near you.
- What do apprentices earn in year 1 and at journeyman level in your area?

Route 4: Straight to a 4-year university

- In-state cost, admission requirements, and what the first two years actually look like (hint: the same calculus/physics you'd take at community college for a third of the price)

For each route, record: total cost, years to a credential, whether you can work while doing it, whether ABET accreditation applies (see the resources file for why you should care), and what door it opens at the end.

For every college on your list, also ask (read `resources/internships-and-coops.md` first — enrollment is the key that unlocks internships and co-ops):

- Do you have a **co-op program**? Which local employers take your students?
- Do students get **Handshake** access, and does the career center place pre-engineering/technology students?

- Which employers sponsor or hire your engineering-track students? (The college knows exactly who.)

Part 2: Essay (700–1000 words)

Prompt: *“My education plan and why I chose it.”*

Requirements:

- Commit to a route (combinations count — e.g., “technician job + community college nights + transfer” is a route).
- Show your work: why this one over the other three? Use your cost and timeline numbers.
- Name the **first three concrete steps** and put a date on each (e.g., “meet with the community college advisor before ,” ***“IBEW application window opens ”***).
- Name the biggest risk to your plan and what you’d do if it happens.

Done when

- ☐ All four routes researched with local specifics
- ☐ Essay written with dated next steps
- ☐ Walkthrough conversation done